

Schools of Buddhism — MCQ Questions

Deterministic source-derived randomization seed: 17762885289694100775.

Coverage derivation: 107 atomic Buddhism-specific test cells were derived first. The final 110-question bank assigns every question one primary cell; 3 high-risk cells receive an additional application or discrimination probe. The total is therefore a consequence of the matrix, not a template target.

Attempt all questions before opening the solutions.

MCQ 1. What the Four Noble Truths are doing

With reference to the Four Noble Truths (*catvāri āryasatyāni*), consider the following statements.

1. The second truth supplies a causal account of how suffering is produced.
2. The third truth is an independent article of faith unconnected with the second.
3. The fourth truth prescribes the discipline by which the causal chain is interrupted.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 2. Three denials that must not be merged

Buddhism is classified as unorthodox (*nāstika*), as non-theistic and as anti-substantialist. These three descriptions respectively rest on its rejection of

- A. renunciation as a way of life, the authority of teachers, and the conventional usefulness of ordinary speech
- B. rebirth across lives, the possibility of liberation, and the validity of inference as a means of knowing
- C. the moral law of action, the practice of meditation, and the reality of the external world as such
- D. Vedic scriptural authority, the explanatory necessity of a creator, and a permanent self behind experience

MCQ 3. What the practical Middle Path actually rejects

In its practical sense, the Middle Path (*madhyamā pratipad*; Pali: *majjhimā paṭipadā*) is best described as

- A. a distinct disciplined route that rejects both sensual indulgence and self-mortification because neither removes craving
- B. an instruction to suspend judgement between rival philosophical positions until further evidence becomes available
- C. a rule of social conduct that regulates the relations between the monastic community and lay supporters
- D. a proportionate blend of moderate enjoyment with moderate austerity, adjusted to the temperament of the practitioner

MCQ 4. Grouping the eight factors

The eight factors of the Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga) are classically grouped under three trainings. Right speech, right action and right livelihood belong to

- A. wisdom (prajñā), because each of them presupposes a correct view of conditioned things
- B. a fourth training of faith, which the tradition adds separately for lay practitioners of the path
- C. meditative discipline (samādhi), because each of them is practised only during formal periods of sitting
- D. ethical discipline (śīla), because each of them regulates outward conduct that renews the conditions of craving

MCQ 5. The doctrinal middle

The doctrinal sense of the Middle Path consists in the rejection of

- A. eternalism (śāśvata-vāda) and annihilationism (uccheda-vāda), in favour of conditioned continuity without a permanent bearer
- B. realism about external objects and idealism about consciousness, in favour of a neutral monism of events
- C. inference as an independent means of knowledge and testimony as a derived one, in favour of perception alone
- D. asceticism as a monastic ideal and ritual as a lay one, in favour of a purely contemplative discipline

MCQ 6. The formula of dependent origination

The standard formula of dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) is significant for Buddhist soteriology chiefly because

- A. it identifies a first cause from which the entire series of conditioned phenomena can be shown to proceed
- B. it establishes that every effect pre-exists in its material cause and is merely manifested when conditions mature
- C. it demonstrates that the relation between cause and effect is a matter of habitual expectation rather than of nature
- D. it states positive conditionality and negative conditionality together, so that cessation is built into the principle itself

MCQ 7. The three marks and their scope

With reference to the three marks (trilakṣaṇa; Pali: tilakkhaṇa), consider the following statements.

1. Impermanence and unsatisfactoriness are standardly predicated of conditioned formations.
2. The mark of no-self is applied more widely than the other two.
3. Impermanence in the early teaching is verbally identical with the later thesis of momentariness.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1, 2 and 3
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 2 and 3 only

MCQ 8. The order of the chain

In the twelve-link sequence (dvādaśa-nidāna), the correct order of the links immediately following name-and-form (nāma-rūpa) is

- A. feeling, contact, six sense-bases, craving
- B. six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving
- C. craving, feeling, six sense-bases, contact
- D. contact, six sense-bases, craving, feeling

MCQ 9. Why the chain is not fatalism

Buddhists deny that the twelve-link chain entails fatalism primarily because

- A. the chain is a purely symbolic representation with no claim to describe the actual conditions of rebirth or suffering
- B. every link may be broken at any point by an act of divine grace conferred independently of the practitioner's effort
- C. the links classified as present causes remain open to alteration, so present practice changes what is subsequently produced
- D. the sequence describes only the experience of unenlightened persons and does not apply to disciplined practitioners

MCQ 10. The criterion behind momentariness

The Buddhist thesis *yat sat tat kṣaṇikam* is grounded on the prior claim that

- A. whatever is perceived by the senses must be composed of parts and is therefore liable to decomposition
- B. whatever is real is capable of producing an effect, so that reality is identified with causal efficacy
- C. whatever is denied by the opponent must be affirmed by the proponent if the debate is to remain intelligible
- D. whatever is described by a general term must be a conceptual construction rather than an ultimately real entity

MCQ 11. The two horns

In the Buddhist argument against a permanent efficient cause, the horn of simultaneity (*yaugapadya*) presses the objection that

- A. a permanent entity producing its whole effect at once leaves nothing available for later production
- B. a permanent entity would require a second permanent entity to destroy it when its function is complete
- C. a permanent entity would have to be perceived as enduring, whereas perception presents only momentary phases
- D. a permanent entity would be unable to enter into any relation with the auxiliary conditions that surround it

MCQ 12. Closing the Nyāya escape route

Nyāya replies that a permanent substance acts only when auxiliary conditions (*sahakārin*) are present. The Buddhist counter-dilemma is that

- A. auxiliary conditions are themselves permanent, so the reply merely postpones the original difficulty by one step
- B. auxiliary conditions cannot be perceived, so their postulation violates the Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge
- C. auxiliary conditions belong to the category of quality, which cannot be causally responsible for the production of a substance

D. either the permanent thing already possesses the power, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing redundant

MCQ 13. How continuity survives momentariness

Under momentariness, the appearance of an enduring object is explained by

- A. an underlying substance that persists while its qualities are successively replaced by similar qualities
- B. an act of divine sustenance that maintains resemblance between successive states of the world
- C. a causal series (santāna) whose successive members are sufficiently similar to be treated as one thing
- D. a permanent witnessing consciousness before which the succession of states is continuously displayed

MCQ 14. The exhaustive analysis of the person

The philosophical force of the five-aggregate (pañca-skandha) analysis lies in the fact that

- A. the enumeration is claimed to be exhaustive, so that failure to find a sixth item is failure to find a self
- B. the analysis is presented as a provisional teaching device that a more advanced practitioner may discard
- C. the aggregates are ranked hierarchically, with consciousness serving as the owner of the remaining four
- D. each aggregate is shown to be permanent in substance while impermanent in its successive modes

MCQ 15. What the chariot analogy establishes

In the chariot analogy of the Milinda-pañha, the philosophical point is that

- A. the chariot is wholly unreal, so that anyone who uses the word is making a straightforward factual mistake
- B. the term functions correctly as a designation without naming any further entity beyond the parts and their arrangement
- C. the chariot is identical with the sum of its parts arranged in a heap, so that the arrangement contributes nothing
- D. the chariot possesses a distinct nature that emerges from the parts and thereafter exists independently of them

MCQ 16. Moral consequence without a permanent self

The Buddhist formula that the later stage is "neither the same nor another" (na sa eva na cānyaḥ) is philosophically necessary because

- A. strict identity is asserted at the conventional level while strict difference is asserted at the ultimate level
- B. strict identity is a Nyāya doctrine while strict difference is a Sāṃkhya doctrine, so both must be rejected as non-Buddhist
- C. strict identity would reinstate eternalism while strict difference would make the fruit fall on an unrelated recipient
- D. strict identity would preserve responsibility while strict difference would preserve impermanence, so both must be affirmed together

MCQ 17. What cessation of conditioned suffering is

Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa; Pali: nibbāna) is most accurately described as

- A. the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, and thereby the ceasing of the process that produces suffering
- B. the complete annihilation of the individual, understood as the destruction of a substance that formerly existed
- C. the attainment by the liberated self of a permanent state of undisturbed bliss in a region beyond the world
- D. the merging of individual consciousness into a universal consciousness from which it had been temporarily separated

MCQ 18. The internal relation of the Three Jewels

In the Buddhist account of the Three Jewels (Triratna), the internal relation among Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha is best stated as

- A. a hierarchy in which the community confers authority on the teaching and the teaching confers authority on the teacher
- B. three independent objects of devotion, each sufficient on its own to secure liberation for the practitioner
- C. a functional triad in which the teacher discovered the path, the teaching liberates, and the community preserves and transmits it
- D. a symbolic triad with no doctrinal content, retained only because the formula of refuge is ritually convenient

MCQ 19. Vaibhāṣika realism and its cost

The Vaibhāṣika affirmation that dharmas of the past, present and future have some mode of existence is best explained as

- A. an inference from the impossibility of partless atoms combining to form perceptible gross objects
- B. an acceptance of an eternal substance underlying the momentary states in which it successively appears
- C. a concession to Mahāyāna criticism that the momentary ontology of the earlier schools was too austere
- D. a device required to keep past acts able to bear future fruit and to give every cognition a genuine object

MCQ 20. The Sautrāntika argument

Sautrāntika concludes that external objects are known only inferentially because

- A. external objects are ultimately unreal, so any cognition of them must be a construction of the mind alone
- B. the senses are unreliable instruments whose deliverances must always be corrected by scriptural testimony
- C. the object-moment has already ceased when the cognition it caused arises, so cognition can only bear its form
- D. universals cannot be perceived, and therefore no cognition of a general object can ever be perceptual

MCQ 21. The three natures

In Yogācāra, the imagined (parikalpita), dependent (paratantra) and perfected (pariṣpanna) natures are best understood as

- A. three distinct realities arranged in ascending order, the lowest being annihilated when the highest is realised
- B. three descriptions of one dependent flow — as falsely taken, as actually running, and as truly seen
- C. three types of cognition, corresponding respectively to perception, inference and testimony
- D. three stages of meditative attainment, corresponding to concentration, insight and final absorption

MCQ 22. From dependence to emptiness

The Mādhyamika derivation of emptiness (śūnyatā) from dependent origination turns on the premise that

- A. whatever possesses intrinsic nature (svabhāva) would exist through itself and would therefore not depend on conditions
- B. whatever is cognised must be identical with the cognition of it, so that no object stands outside awareness
- C. whatever is expressed by a word must be a construction, so that only the ineffable particular can be ultimately real
- D. whatever is composite must eventually decompose, so that no composite thing can be counted as ultimately real

MCQ 23. The label that is not a name

Which of the following statements about Buddhist tradition-labels is accurate?

- A. Theravāda is one surviving school with the Pali canon, while Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika belong to the Sarvāstivāda world
- B. Theravāda, Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are three names for a single school opposed to a uniform Mahāyāna system
- C. "Hīnayāna" was the shared self-designation of the early schools before Mahāyāna adopted a different name
- D. Vaibhāṣika and Yogācāra are Theravāda formations, while Sautrāntika and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna formations

MCQ 24. Store-consciousness is not a self

Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) differs from the self (ātman) rejected by Buddhism because it is

- A. confined to the present life and destroyed at death, so that it cannot support rebirth or moral consequence
- B. imperceptible to ordinary cognition and therefore knowable only through the testimony of an authoritative teacher
- C. a conditioned and continually transforming stream that carries seeds rather than an unchanging substantial owner
- D. shared among all sentient beings as a single cosmic reservoir in which individual experience is temporarily located

MCQ 25. The type of negation

Mādhyamaka denial of all four corners of the catuṣkoṭi avoids contradiction because the negation employed is

- A. provisional, so that the denials are withdrawn once the opponent has been silenced in the course of debate
- B. non-implicative (prasajya-pratiṣedha) and scoped to things taken as possessing intrinsic nature, so no fifth thesis is installed
- C. merely rhetorical, so that the denials are not intended as claims and carry no philosophical commitment at all
- D. implicative (paryudāsa-pratiṣedha), so that denying each corner asserts the remaining alternatives in turn

MCQ 26. Buddhist means of knowledge

The Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) is argued from

- A. the scriptural authority of the Buddha, whose word settles disputes about the correct enumeration of knowledge-sources
- B. the claim that means of knowing are fixed by the distinct kinds of objects to be known

- C. the practical observation that comparison and testimony rarely yield certainty in ordinary human affairs
- D. the impossibility of establishing invariable concomitance, which restricts valid knowledge to immediate perception

MCQ 27. Exclusion and its critics

The objection that the exclusion theory of meaning (apoha) is circular holds that

- A. excluding non-cows presupposes already knowing what a cow is, so the account assumes what it set out to explain
- B. exclusion presupposes momentariness, which has not itself been established independently of the theory of meaning
- C. exclusion cannot apply to negative terms, since there is no positive class from which the exclusion could be made
- D. exclusion applies only to words and not to concepts, so it cannot explain the generality present in thought itself

MCQ 28. Reading the silence

The most defensible reading of the Buddha's refusal to answer the undeclared (avyākṛta) questions is that

- A. he lacked the relevant knowledge, which is why the tradition preserves the questions without preserving answers
- B. the questions were philosophically trivial and were dismissed because they had no bearing on any doctrine
- C. the questions were reserved for advanced disciples and were answered privately outside the public discourses
- D. the questions are both unconvincing to liberation and defective in presupposing a substantial self or world

MCQ 29. The comparison most often written wrongly

In comparing Buddhism with Jainism, which of the following is accurate?

- A. Both accept Vedic authority, but Jainism restricts it to ethics while Buddhism restricts it to meditative practice
- B. Both affirm a permanent self, but Jainism treats it as omniscient while Buddhism treats it as momentary in nature
- C. Both reject a creator God, but Jainism affirms a real conscious soul while Buddhism denies any permanent self
- D. Both deny the soul, but Jainism explains continuity by karmic matter while Buddhism explains it by a causal series

MCQ 30. Why cessation follows

Which inference correctly connects dependent origination with the third Noble Truth?

- A. Because suffering is unreal, insight merely reveals that it never occurred.
- B. If suffering occurs only while its sustaining conditions obtain, removing those conditions entails cessation.
- C. Because liberation is guaranteed by the Buddha's authority independently of causal practice.
- D. Because every effect must return into a permanent material cause.

MCQ 31. Three readings of twelve links

Which account best relates the three-life, present-process and structural readings of the twelve links?

- A. Only the three-life reading is canonical; the others deny rebirth.
- B. The structural reading turns the links into twelve simultaneous substances.
- C. The three readings are compatible lenses on cross-life, present-process and structural dependence.
- D. The present-process reading replaces causal explanation with phenomenological description.

MCQ 32. Conditionality without linearity

A student says dependent origination must be a single chain beginning with a first event. What is the best correction?

- A. Every link is only a metaphor, so no causal order is asserted.
- B. Conditional dependence allows cyclic and reciprocal patterns without requiring any first cause.
- C. All twelve links occur simultaneously and therefore have no temporal uses.
- D. The chain begins with ignorance, which is therefore an unconditioned first cause.

MCQ 33. Impermanence is not yet momentariness

Why does the inference 'conditioned things change; therefore each lasts exactly one moment' require an additional premise?

- A. Momentariness follows only from scriptural testimony and cannot be argued.
- B. Ordinary impermanence permits enduring but changing continuants; strict momentariness requires the causal-efficacy dilemma against permanence.
- C. Impermanence applies only to minds, whereas momentariness applies only to bodies.
- D. The early teaching accepts a permanent substance beneath changing qualities.

MCQ 34. The succession horn

What does the succession horn (krama) argue against a permanent cause?

- A. A permanent cause cannot coexist with any auxiliary conditions.
- B. Successive production is impossible because time is unreal.
- C. If it produces successively, every later effect must already exist in the cause.
- D. Successive effects require differing causal performance, contradicting a wholly unchanged cause.

MCQ 35. Perishing without a destroyer

Why do Buddhist momentarists deny that a distinct external destroyer is required for each thing's cessation?

- A. A conditioned event exhausts itself in arising, without awaiting an external destroyer.
- B. Because destruction is a permanent substance present inside every object.
- C. Because non-existence acts backwards in time upon the thing.
- D. Because perception directly observes an infinitesimal destruction-particle.

MCQ 36. Memory without a witness

Which mechanism best explains memory in a momentary stream without postulating an enduring knower?

- A. A later cognition inherits an earlier cognition's disposition and actualizes it as memory.
- B. Memory is invalid and therefore needs no causal explanation.
- C. The numerically same cognition remains latent and later reappears.
- D. A permanent self stores representations while mental events change.

MCQ 37. Conventional personal identity

On the strongest Buddhist account, what makes the person at a later time conventionally the same person?

- A. Possession of one immutable consciousness common to every life.
- B. Mere bodily resemblance, even without causal connection.
- C. Causal continuity supporting memory and accountability grounds conventional personal identity.
- D. Numerical identity of all five aggregates across time.

MCQ 38. Action and responsibility

Which formulation best preserves Buddhist moral responsibility under no-self?

- A. Volition qualifies action, while the later causal stream inherits its consequences.
- B. A subtle agent survives only for moral cases and disappears in meditation.
- C. The act belongs to no one, so karmic fruit is allocated impersonally at random.
- D. Responsibility is impossible because only numerical identity can ground desert.

MCQ 39. What perception reaches

In Buddhist epistemology, why is the svalakṣaṇa assigned to perception rather than conceptual judgement?

- A. It is the permanent substance supporting changing qualities.
- B. It is a universal present identically in many instances.
- C. It is a linguistic meaning fixed by reliable testimony.
- D. Perception reaches a causally efficacious particular; exclusion supplies conceptual generality.

MCQ 40. How apoha forms a concept

How can the word 'cow' function, according to apoha, if no real universal cowhood is admitted?

- A. It denotes a separately existing universal perceived in each cow.
- B. It guides cognition by excluding non-cows among particulars that converge in relevant causal capacities.

- C. It refers to one privileged archetypal cow copied by all others.
- D. It has no cognitive content and works only through social habit.

MCQ 41. Creator as an unnecessary posit

Which Buddhist criticism most directly targets a creator introduced to explain the ordered causal world?

- A. Creation is refuted because the Vedas never mention a deity.
- B. Complete conditional explanation makes a creator redundant; intervention revives partiality problems.
- C. Any first cause must be material and therefore visible.
- D. A creator is impossible solely because no being can be morally good.

MCQ 42. Four historical labels

Which statement keeps early Buddhism, Theravāda, 'Hīnayāna' and Mahāyāna historically distinct?

- A. Theravāda is an early lineage, Hīnayāna a polemical label, and Mahāyāna diverse movements.
- B. Early Buddhism is simply the doctrinal system of later Vaibhāṣika.
- C. Mahāyāna is one school with a single ontology opposed to the Pali canon.
- D. Theravāda and Hīnayāna are neutral synonyms for every non-Mahāyāna school.

MCQ 43. Vaibhāṣika direct realism

What makes Vaibhāṣika realism 'direct'?

- A. Only consciousness exists, but it projects an external-seeming object.
- B. Universals are directly perceived as permanent entities.
- C. Vaibhāṣika perception directly takes a present external particular as its object.
- D. All three times are perceived simultaneously in one cognition.

MCQ 44. Sautrāntika seeds

What role do 'seeds' play in a Sautrāntika account?

- A. They are Platonic forms copied by momentary particulars.
- B. Seeds are transmitted causal capacities explaining delayed effects without persisting dharmas.
- C. They are microscopic permanent substances stored in the soul.
- D. They are external objects directly perceived before cognition arises.

MCQ 45. Co-cognition

What does the Yogācāra co-cognition (sahopalambha) argument claim?

- A. Awareness is a permanent substance while blue is momentary.
- B. Blue is inferred from awareness because it always precedes awareness.
- C. Every perceiver shares numerically the same awareness of blue.
- D. Blue and blue-awareness are never separately apprehended, weakening independent subject-object duality.

MCQ 46. Dream argument

What conclusion can the Yogācāra dream argument establish without overreaching?

- A. Only the dreamer's permanent self is ultimately real.
- B. Nothing whatsoever exists because dreams are unreal.
- C. Dream-like appearance shows that seeming externality does not prove an external correlate.
- D. Waking and dream cognitions are identical in every practical respect.

MCQ 47. Atom-composition pressure

What is the distinct burden of Yogācāra's atom argument against an external gross object?

- A. It argues that waking experience lacks the regularity found in dreams.
- B. The argument attacks whether partless atoms can combine, or whether divisible atoms can remain ultimate.
- C. It argues that an external cause has already ceased before its cognition arises.
- D. It argues that all cognition belongs to one permanent cosmic mind.

MCQ 48. Not private idealism

Which feature most clearly prevents Yogācāra from collapsing into 'my private mind invents everything'?

- A. External atoms secretly remain as causes of every representation.
- B. A single eternal world-mind guarantees everyone the same objects.
- C. Truth is whatever an individual can imagine consistently.
- D. Constructed subjects and shared karmic seeds allow stable experience without private-ego idealism.

MCQ 49. How prasaṅga works

In Madhyamaka debate, what is the point of prasaṅga?

- A. To prove a positive Madhyamaka substance by syllogism.
- B. To suspend all reasoning because logic is conventional.
- C. To assert all four alternatives of the catuṣkoṭi simultaneously.
- D. Prasaṅga exposes consequences of svabhāva without establishing a rival essence.

MCQ 50. Why emptiness is not nihilism

Which proposition best states Madhyamaka's anti-nihilist reply?

- A. Emptiness permits dependent functioning; sheer nonexistence could not function.
- B. Some privileged dharmas retain intrinsic nature to ground the rest.
- C. Emptiness is a subtle substance that supports changing phenomena.
- D. Ultimate truth cancels causation, ethics and language as false.

MCQ 51. Escalation among schools

Which sequence correctly represents a major inter-school escalation?

- A. Madhyamaka returns to Vaibhāṣika direct realism after refuting Yogācāra.
- B. Realism yields to representation, then representation-only, then emptiness of consciousness.
- C. All four schools accept the same ontology and differ only in meditation.
- D. Vaibhāṣika denies objects; Sautrāntika restores them; Yogācāra makes them permanent; Madhyamaka makes them mental.

MCQ 52. Direct and indirect realism

Two cognitions have the same phenomenal form. How would Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika differ about their external object?

- A. Vaibhāṣika directly perceives externals; Sautrāntika infers them from caused representations.
- B. Vaibhāṣika infers the object while Sautrāntika directly perceives it.
- C. Both directly perceive a universal instantiated in the object.
- D. Both deny external objects but disagree about store-consciousness.

MCQ 53. Yogācāra and Madhyamaka

What is the sharpest Madhyamaka criticism of a Yogācāra formulation that makes consciousness ultimately real?

- A. It admits too many external atoms.
- B. It denies all conventional cognition and practice.
- C. It accepts a permanent personal soul.
- D. It rejects objects but still reifies consciousness.

MCQ 54. Nyāya and Buddhist self

Which issue most directly separates Nyāya's self from the Buddhist causal series?

- A. Nyāya denies memory while Buddhism accepts it.
- B. Nyāya requires an enduring owner; Buddhism uses conventionally unified causal events.

C. Buddhism accepts an eternal witness inaccessible to Nyāya inference.

D. Nyāya makes the self momentary while Buddhism makes it bodily.

MCQ 55. Cārvāka and Buddhist denials

How does Cārvāka's rejection of a transcendental self differ from Buddhist no-self?

A. Buddhism denies embodiment while Cārvāka alone accepts perception.

B. Cārvāka affirms a permanent material soul while Buddhism affirms a mental soul.

C. Cārvāka ends consciousness with the body; Buddhism preserves karmic continuity without self.

D. Cārvāka and Buddhism both deny consciousness after every moment.

MCQ 56. Knowing absence

In the jar-absence debate, which contrast is most accurate?

A. Both treat absence as a permanent universal directly perceived.

B. Nyāya perceives real absence; Buddhism constructs it through non-apprehension and exclusion.

C. Neither system permits valid cognition of absence.

D. Buddhists treat absence as a substance while Nyāya treats it as fiction.

MCQ 57. Pramāṇa and its result

Which formulation captures the Buddhist pressure on Nyāya's pramāṇa/pramāṇaphala distinction?

A. Buddhism denies every distinction between cause and effect.

B. Both systems make an eternal self the pramāṇa.

C. Nyāya identifies every valid pramāṇa exclusively with authoritative testimony.

D. Buddhism unifies cognition and result functionally; Nyāya distinguishes instrument from result.

MCQ 58. The owner of memory objection

What is the strongest Nyāya objection to explaining memory by a causally connected series alone?

A. Momentary events cannot cause later events under any conditions.

B. Memory requires direct perception of the past object.

C. Causal succession explains production, not first-person ownership of an earlier cognition.

D. A causal series cannot contain any similarity between stages.

MCQ 59. Nyāya's power reply

How can Nyāya resist the Buddhist succession horn without claiming that the substance itself changes?

- A. It can identify every auxiliary with the permanent substance.
- B. An enduring substance may possess powers activated differently by changing auxiliaries.
- C. It can deny that causes ever produce effects.
- D. It can accept that the substance lasts for only one moment.

MCQ 60. Emptying consciousness

Why does Madhyamaka reject an ultimately self-established store-consciousness even if it explains continuity?

- A. Because a permanent personal self is preferable.
- B. Ālaya may work conventionally while remaining dependently arisen and empty.
- C. Because continuity is wholly unreal at the conventional level.
- D. Because only external matter can carry karmic seeds.

MCQ 61. Shared worlds without external objects

What is Yogācāra's best reply to the claim that representation-only makes disagreement and shared experience impossible?

- A. Interacting karmic seed-streams can condition shared appearances without one private ego.
- B. Disagreement proves that no cognition has any validity.
- C. All persons are modes of one permanent cosmic subject.
- D. External objects are admitted whenever two observers agree.

MCQ 62. Pudgalavāda foil

Why is Pudgalavāda a revealing foil for mainstream Buddhist no-self?

- A. Pudgalavāda posits an ineffable aggregate-related person to secure agency and responsibility.
- B. It openly restores the Upaniṣadic eternal ātman as a sixth aggregate.
- C. It is a Madhyamaka name for the conventional person.
- D. It denies karma and rebirth because no person can continue.

MCQ 63. Refuge without a soul

How can refuge in the Three Jewels remain consistent with no-self?

- A. Nirvāṇa is bestowed on a soul by the Buddha.
- B. Only the Saṅgha has a collective permanent self.
- C. The refuge formula temporarily suspends no-self for religious purposes.
- D. A conventional causal stream can learn, transform and take refuge without a soul.

MCQ 64. Historical overstatement

Which sentence commits a historical-layer error?

- A. A modern answer should identify when a proof belongs to later scholastic Buddhism.
- B. Early discourses teach impermanence without requiring every later scholastic argument.
- C. Later Buddhist logicians radicalize impermanence into a strict momentariness thesis.
- D. The earliest discourses teach Dharmakīrti's fully articulated causal-efficacy proof in its later technical form.

MCQ 65. Not an arithmetic mean

A candidate writes that the Middle Path recommends 'half indulgence and half asceticism'. What is the precise defect?

- A. It confuses Mahāyāna with Theravāda.
- B. It makes the path too doctrinal and insufficiently practical.
- C. The Middle Path rejects extremes through an eightfold discipline.
- D. It understates the amount of asceticism recommended.

MCQ 66. Representationalism is still realism

Which claim would turn Sautrāntika into a position it does not hold?

- A. Access may be indirect while existence remains mind-independent.
- B. Because only a representation is immediately known, no external cause exists at all.
- C. The external object is inferred from the cognition-form it caused.
- D. The cause precedes the cognition in a momentary sequence.

MCQ 67. Emptiness is empty

What does 'the emptiness of emptiness' prevent?

- A. It reverses emptiness and restores substantial dharmas.
- B. It prevents any use of conventional language.
- C. It proves that only consciousness is ultimately real.
- D. Emptiness is itself dependent, preventing it from becoming an ultimate essence.

MCQ 68. Answer-spine ordering

For a question asking how dependent origination proves momentariness, which answer sequence is strongest?

- A. Describe the Buddha's life → define nirvāṇa → compare Jainism → conclude.
- B. Define conditionality → derive impermanence → add causal efficacy → state simultaneity/succession horns → meet auxiliaries → preserve continuity.

- C. Define momentariness → list twelve links → assert that change is obvious → conclude.
- D. State causal efficacy → deny all continuity → call the result annihilationism.

MCQ 69. Ownership-sensitive school answer

Which introduction best frames a comparison of the four syllabus schools?

- A. All four teach the same no-self doctrine and differ only in terminology.
- B. Theravāda first split into Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Madhyamaka.
- C. Buddhism evolved linearly from false realism to the final truth of Madhyamaka.
- D. Compare historically layered schools by objects, cognitive access and intrinsic nature.

MCQ 70. Karma objection-reply structure

Which structure best answers a critical question on momentariness and karma?

- A. Present the ownership objection, causal-continuity reply, karmic mechanism and residual desert problem.
- B. Deny that later consequences belong to anyone → call this liberation.
- C. Introduce a permanent self to carry merit → defend momentariness separately.
- D. Assert karma is a religious belief → cite rebirth → omit objections.

MCQ 71. Intervention at feeling

A practitioner experiences an unpleasant feeling. In twelve-link terms, where is the most immediate disciplined intervention?

- A. Reverse birth directly while leaving craving intact.
- B. Eliminate the six sense-bases by refusing all perception.
- C. Mindfulness interrupts the feeling-to-craving condition, weakening clinging and becoming.
- D. Find the first historical ignorance that began the series.

MCQ 72. Responsibility in a changing person

A court treats a reformed adult as responsible for an earlier act despite extensive psychological change. Which Buddhist analogy is strongest?

- A. An eternal legal soul preserves every property unchanged.
- B. The adult is numerically unrelated, so punishment necessarily targets a stranger.
- C. Conventional identity is arbitrary, so any person could be punished.
- D. Legal responsibility can follow causal continuity, memory and inherited dispositions without self-sameness.

MCQ 73. Diagnosing a nirvāṇa answer

Which sentence should be deleted first from an answer defending nirvāṇa under no-self?

- A. A causal stream can undergo discipline without an additional owner.
- B. Conventional discourse may still say that a person is liberated.
- C. After liberation, the eternal subject possesses nirvāṇa as its unchanging private state.
- D. Nirvāṇa names cessation of greed, aversion and delusion.

MCQ 74. PYQ 2018: dependence to emptiness

Which thesis is indispensable in a direct answer to the 2018 demand asking how Madhyamaka applies dependent origination to establish emptiness?

- A. Dependent things are unreal because only a permanent cause can be real.
- B. Whatever depends on causes and designation lacks svabhāva; emptiness is not non-being.
- C. Emptiness is inferred from the identity of cognition and object.
- D. The twelve links end in a transcendent substance called emptiness.

MCQ 75. PYQ 2018: no-self and nirvāṇa

What is the strongest consistency defence for no-self and nirvāṇa?

- A. Nirvāṇa annihilates the self after it completes practice.
- B. A permanent self appears only at liberation.
- C. No-self removes appropriation; nirvāṇa ceases that process rather than rewarding a self.
- D. No-self is conventional but an eternal subject is ultimate.

MCQ 76. PYQ 2019: external world

Which answer set directly satisfies the 2019 Yogācāra 'how' demand?

- A. List the five aggregates and explain personal no-self.
- B. Assert that one private mind creates whatever it wishes.
- C. Dream, atom and time-gap arguments challenge externality; karmic seeds explain shared order.
- D. Only define vijñaptimātra and state that matter is illusion.

MCQ 77. PYQ 2019: apply dependence to momentariness

Which conditional sub-argument best performs the 2019 demand to apply dependent origination to momentariness?

- A. A permanent producer either acts all at once or changes with conditions.
- B. A dependent thing must have a first unconditioned material cause that remains identical.
- C. A momentary event cannot condition another event because it has already ceased.

D. A changing thing is momentary simply because both words exclude eternity.

MCQ 78. PYQ 2020: logical derivative

Which critical qualification belongs in the 2020 'logical derivative' answer?

- A. The derivation succeeds only by accepting a permanent efficient cause.
- B. The two doctrines are unrelated and merely historically adjacent.
- C. Momentariness follows only through the explicit premise that reality is causal efficacy.
- D. Dependent origination already literally states one-moment duration.

MCQ 79. PYQ 2020: aggregates and liberation

Which answer move connects the two halves of the 2020 aggregates-and-liberation demand?

- A. Liberation transforms and ceases the aggregate stream, not a separate sixth entity.
- B. Conclude that no one practises and therefore liberation is impossible.
- C. After listing five aggregates, introduce consciousness as their permanent owner.
- D. Treat liberation as destruction of the physical aggregate alone.

MCQ 80. PYQ 2021: two no-selves

Which distinction directly answers the 2021 question?

- A. The first is Madhyamaka and the second is early Theravāda.
- B. They are exact synonyms used by different languages.
- C. Personal no-self denies an aggregate-owner; dharma no-self denies intrinsic nature universally.
- D. The first denies matter and the second denies mind.

MCQ 81. PYQ 2021: memory and identity

Which response best meets the 'critically discuss' clause in the 2021 memory question?

- A. Use ālaya as the universal Buddhist answer without historical qualification.
- B. Use causal dispositions and conventional identity, then assess the unresolved ownership objection.
- C. Deny that memory occurs because all cognitions perish.
- D. State that memory proves a permanent self and abandon momentariness.

MCQ 82. PYQ 2022: momentariness and karma

Which proposition best answers the compatibility issue in the 2022 karma question?

- A. Momentariness means consequences are random because causes perish.

- B. The doctrine is compatible only if rebirth is denied.
- C. Karma requires a permanent soul, so Buddhism secretly accepts one.
- D. Karma uses causal inheritance, while deserved ownership remains the central objection.

MCQ 83. PYQ 2022: Three Jewels

Which relation-and-consistency claim best answers the 2022 Triratna demand?

- A. Each Jewel independently grants liberation to an eternal devotee.
- B. The Saṅgha creates the Dharma by collective agreement.
- C. Functionally related Jewels guide a conventional practitioner-stream without requiring an immutable soul.
- D. No-self makes refuge grammatically and causally impossible.

MCQ 84. PYQ 2023: soteriology through conditionality

Why can ignorance of dependent origination be called suffering and knowledge of it cessation?

- A. Knowledge magically erases past events from existence.
- B. Ignorance is the unconditioned first cause of the universe.
- C. Insight removes self-misapprehension, thereby weakening craving and its downstream conditions.
- D. Knowledge reveals a permanent self untouched by suffering.

MCQ 85. PYQ 2024: real and void

How can 'everything is real' and 'everything is void' arise from dependent origination without being simple contradiction?

- A. Vaibhāṣika affirms functioning dharmas; Madhyamaka denies intrinsic nature to dependent phenomena.
- B. Vaibhāṣika and Madhyamaka use the words with identical meanings but one makes a factual error.
- C. Madhyamaka rejects dependent origination entirely, whereas Vaibhāṣika alone accepts conditioned arising.
- D. The opposition is mainly between Theravāda discipline and Mahāyāna ritual practice.

MCQ 86. PYQ 2025: nirvāṇa with two denials

Which synthesis best addresses nirvāṇa's consonance with momentariness and no-self?

- A. Nirvāṇa is the annihilation of a momentary soul.
- B. Mutable conditioned processes can cease, without nirvāṇa becoming a permanent subject's possession.
- C. No-self is suspended at liberation so that someone can enjoy it.
- D. Momentariness applies to nirvāṇa as a rapidly vanishing pleasure.

MCQ 87. PYQ 2026: action and responsibility

What should the 2026 answer identify as the unresolved critical issue after presenting Buddhist causal continuity?

- A. Whether a creator assigns consequences to each soul.
- B. Test whether inherited intention secures desert without numerical personal identity.
- C. Whether the Vedas authorize karmic responsibility.
- D. Whether momentary events can ever occur in temporal order.

MCQ 88. Supporting PYQ: absence

What two axes must structure the supporting 2018 Buddhism-Nyāya absence answer?

- A. Whether both schools deny all negative facts.
- B. Whether inference is valid and scripture is eternal.
- C. Whether jars are substances and tables are universals.
- D. Separate absence's ontology from its perceptual or constructed cognition.

MCQ 89. Supporting PYQ: two self denials

Which contrast is mandatory in the supporting 2024 Cārvāka-Buddhist self question?

- A. Both preserve rebirth through an eternal material soul.
- B. Cārvāka ends embodied consciousness; Buddhism retains karmic rebirth through causal continuity.
- C. Buddhism reduces consciousness to the four gross elements exactly as Cārvāka does.
- D. Cārvāka accepts karma while Buddhism rejects it.

MCQ 90. Supporting PYQ: instrument and result

What is the conceptual centre of the supporting 2025 Nyāya-Buddhist debate?

- A. Whether absence must be admitted as a separate seventh ontological category.
- B. Whether every inferential cognition must be rejected as inherently uncertain.
- C. Whether authoritative testimony alone can establish every possible object of knowledge.
- D. Compare whether cognition, result and knower are distinct entities or momentary functions.

MCQ 91. Two truths are not two realities

Which reading of Madhyamaka's two truths is correct?

- A. Ultimate truth is a hidden object perceived after conventions disappear.
- B. They are two separate worlds, one false and one permanently real.
- C. Both truths describe dependently arisen phenomena as functional yet empty of svabhāva.

D. Conventional truth is sheer error with no role in liberation.

MCQ 92. Ālaya under pressure

Which pair states both the explanatory gain and philosophical risk of ālaya-vijñāna?

- A. Ālaya carries seeds through change but cannot be a self-established subject.
- B. It proves external atoms; its risk is direct realism.
- C. It abolishes karma; its risk is moral fatalism.
- D. It is an eternal witness; its risk is that it changes.

MCQ 93. Arhat and bodhisattva ideals

Which comparison preserves the historical nuance between arhat and bodhisattva ideals?

- A. The contrast identifies dominant aims, not mutually exclusive vocabularies or a selfish-versus-altruistic binary.
- B. Theravāda rejects every bodhisattva career, while Mahāyāna rejects the category of arhat.
- C. Arhat and bodhisattva are interchangeable names for one institutional rank in every Buddhist school.
- D. The bodhisattva merely delays an otherwise identical arhat goal until all beings are liberated.

MCQ 94. Definition of perception

How do Dignāga and Dharmakīrti jointly define valid Buddhist perception?

- A. Both count every vivid appearance as valid perception, including illusion.
- B. Dignāga makes perception conceptual, and Dharmakīrti restricts it to testimony.
- C. Dignāga defines perception as inference, and Dharmakīrti adds universal recognition.
- D. Dignāga excludes conceptual construction, and Dharmakīrti also excludes erroneous non-conceptual appearance.

MCQ 95. Four kinds of perception

Which list gives the fourfold perception division in the Buddhist pramāṇa tradition?

- A. Sense perception, mental perception, cognition's self-awareness and disciplined yogic perception.
- B. External perception, universal perception, scriptural perception and recollection.
- C. Sense perception, inference, comparison and testimony.
- D. Visual perception, auditory perception, touch and conceptual judgement.

MCQ 96. Mīmāṃsā enduring-agent objection

How does Buddhism answer the Mīmāṃsā claim that one enduring agent must perform, own and later receive the result of an action?

- A. Agency is unreal, so no intention or later result needs an owner or explanation.

- B. The same permanent knower remains unchanged while actions and results occur around it.
- C. A universal called agency migrates between momentary cognitions and unifies them.
- D. A causally connected cognition-stream can inherit intentions and results without one numerically identical agent persisting throughout.

MCQ 97. Mīmāṃsā universals objection

How does Buddhist apoha answer the Mīmāṃsā objection that words require positive, repeatable universals?

- A. Exclusion and recurrent causal capacities stabilize word-use without positive universals.
- B. A permanent speaker-self creates universals whenever a word is uttered.
- C. Each word directly perceives an eternal universal present identically in all particulars.
- D. Words have no repeatable use because only unique particulars exist.

MCQ 98. Advaita synchronic-unity objection

How can Buddhism answer Advaita's claim that simultaneous features of one experience require a single witness-consciousness?

- A. A permanent witness is admitted conventionally but denied only after liberation.
- B. Unity is impossible, because every momentary cognition is wholly unrelated to every other.
- C. Mutually conditioning cognitions and reflexive awareness can integrate one episode without an invariant witness standing behind it.
- D. Store-consciousness is the changeless witness that illuminates all simultaneous contents.

MCQ 99. Advaita diachronic-liberation objection

How does Buddhism answer Advaita's claim that bondage and liberation must belong to one enduring subject across time?

- A. Liberation creates a permanent self that retrospectively owned every prior moment.
- B. Brahman alone is liberated, while the Buddhist stream disappears without causal consequence.
- C. No-self makes bondage and liberation wholly unrelated, so practice cannot transform a life.
- D. A conventionally identified causal continuum can undergo bondage and cessation without a numerically identical self owning both states.

MCQ 100. Creator regress

What regress problem arises when a creator's purposive act is used to explain the world?

- A. Creation is impossible because effects never depend on causes.
- B. A creator cannot be inferred because every inference requires direct perception of its conclusion.
- C. Divine will merely relocates the question of what explains purposive creation.
- D. A creator must be one of the five aggregates and therefore bodily.

MCQ 101. Creator partiality

What is the distinct partiality objection to a benevolent creator?

- A. Divine partiality follows merely from the creator being timeless.
- B. Every unequal outcome proves that causal regularity is absent.
- C. A creator is partial only if embodied in one social group.
- D. Unequal outcomes imply arbitrary creation unless karma constrains and limits divine authorship.

MCQ 102. Time-gap argument

What is the distinct Yogācāra use of the time gap between external cause and cognition?

- A. The expired external cause is explanatorily idle when only cognition presents the form.
- B. Because atoms cannot have parts, the external object cannot be composed.
- C. Because dreams are vivid, every waking cognition is false.
- D. Because cognition is delayed, it must belong to a permanent self.

MCQ 103. No-self and nirvāṇa

What resolves the apparent inconsistency between no-self and nirvāṇa?

- A. Liberation is cessation within a causal stream, not a permanent subject acquiring an everlasting property.
- B. Nirvāṇa belongs only to the Buddha and not to practitioners.
- C. A self is created at the final moment to receive liberation.
- D. The pre-liberation self is annihilated after completing the path.

MCQ 104. Scope of the three marks

Which scope statement about the three marks is most accurate?

- A. Not-self applies only to persons, whereas every dharma has a permanent core.
- B. Conditioned formations are impermanent and painful; not-self has wider scope.
- C. Nirvāṇa must be momentary because everything without self is conditioned.
- D. All three marks apply only to physical objects and never to cognition.

MCQ 105. Canon and language caution

Which statement is historically safest about Buddhist canons and languages?

- A. Language alone determines whether a doctrine is Mahāyāna or non-Mahāyāna.
- B. Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika use the Theravāda Pāli canon as their sole authority.

- C. Buddhist materials survive across Pāli, Sanskrit, Chinese, Tibetan and fragmentary witnesses.
- D. All early Buddhist discourse is uniquely Pāli and all Mahāyāna teaching is uniquely Sanskrit.

MCQ 106. Recognition by similarity

How does similarity contribute to the Buddhist explanation of recognition without an enduring object?

- A. Recognition is always invalid because no relation can connect different moments.
- B. A later causal phase resembles an earlier phase closely enough for conventional recognition without numerical identity.
- C. The identical earlier object survives unchanged and is directly encountered again.
- D. A permanent universal remembers each object and transfers its identity to later stages.

MCQ 107. Can empty words deny emptiness?

How does Madhyamaka answer the charge that denying every thesis is itself a self-refuting thesis?

- A. Its denial is conventionally operative but empty of intrinsic authority, like one dependent construction undoing another.
- B. It abandons reasoning and relies solely on ineffable mystical experience.
- C. It asserts all four catuṣkoṭi alternatives together as a higher contradiction.
- D. It makes the denial an ultimately true substance exempt from emptiness.

MCQ 108. Complete path grouping

Which allocation of the Eightfold Path is correct?

- A. Wisdom: right view/intention; ethics: right speech/action/livelihood; meditation: right effort/mindfulness/concentration.
- B. Wisdom: view alone; ethics: speech/action; meditation: all remaining factors.
- C. All eight belong equally to meditation because the path is contemplative.
- D. Wisdom: view and speech; ethics: intention and action; meditation: livelihood, effort, mindfulness and concentration.

MCQ 109. Rebirth without transmigration

Which analogy least misleadingly represents Buddhist rebirth?

- A. A traveller leaving one house and entering another unchanged.
- B. A creator assigning a new body to the same soul.
- C. A jewel temporarily hidden in different boxes.
- D. One lamp lights another without a numerically identical flame migrating.

MCQ 110. Dependence has different school uses

Which contrast shows why one premise can support Vaibhāṣika realism and Madhyamaka emptiness?

- A. Vaibhāṣika accepts causation while Madhyamaka rejects it.
- B. Madhyamaka makes every cause permanent while Vaibhāṣika makes it mental.
- C. The schools differ only over terminology for the same ultimate entities.
- D. Vaibhāṣika tests causal efficacy; Madhyamaka tests whether dependent things have svabhāva.